

Beyond Time Zones:

How Unconscious
Cultural Assumptions
Impact Remote Team
Success

Team 43



Objective 01

To assess how remote work environments influence perceived inclusion and access to opportunities across culturally diverse teams.

Objective 02

To identify the impact of cultural, linguistic, and communication-style differences on participation, recognition, and psychological safety in remote teams.

Objective 03

To examine how subtle perception-based biases (e.g., visual background, virtual presence, caregiving assumptions) affect fairness, engagement, and career progression in remote settings.

Scope & Objectives

Project Scope

This project focuses on individuals and teams who work in remote or hybrid environments and interact with their clients and team members mainly through online platforms. Our target group includes technically skilled professionals from culturally diverse backgrounds across different experience levels.

The study aims to understand how subtle cultural biases, perception-based assumptions, and communication differences in remote settings impact inclusion, fairness, engagement, psychological safety, and overall professional growth.



Project Timeline



Risk Management Plan

The key risks identified are primarily related to operational, technical, and resource constraints, including interview cancellations, team member unavailability, and potential data loss. Guided by the principle that **prevention is better than cure**, the team has established proactive mitigation and contingency measures to ensure project continuity and timely completion.

Risk

- Team Member Unavailability
- Data Loss
- Interviewee cancels or does not attend
- Recording Issue during Interviews and Presentation

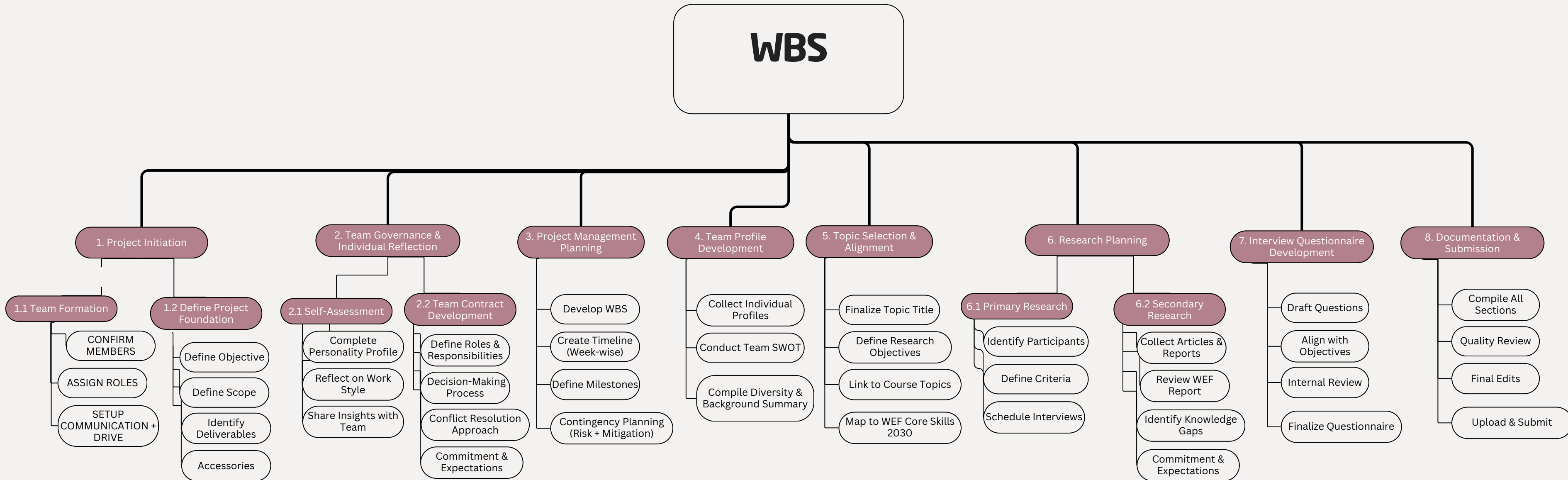
Mitigation Strategy

- Maintain open communication and proactive task planning with clear deadlines and progress tracking.
- Back up all project documents in a shared Google Drive repository and enable autosave while working on local machines.
- Confirm availability before scheduling and send reminders to avoid no-show
- Conduct sound and video checks prior to recording and ensure a stable internet connection before the interview session.

Contingency Plan

- Redistribute the pending tasks among available team members to ensure project continuity.
- Through restore option in drive we can recover the last saved file
- Reschedule the interview or proceed with a backup interviewee if necessary.
- If technical issues occur on the interviewee's side, request a recorded offline video response or reschedule the session.

WBS



Team 43 Dashboard					
Add Channel Overview List Board Calendar Gantt Table + View					
Group: None Show Save view Filter Closed Assignee Add Task					
	Name	Assignee	Status	Due date	Priority
1	Team Formation	Sharmila	COMPLETE	2/12/26	
2	Team Registration	Sharmila	COMPLETE	2/13/26	High
3	Topic Discussion an...	Priyangshu, Sharmila	COMPLETE	2/14/26	Urgent
4	Define Roles and Respons...		COMPLETE	2/13/26	
5	Deliverable 1.a Completion		COMPLETE	2/16/26	Urgent
6	Self Assessment Templ...	Priyangshu Bhattacharyya	COMPLETE	2/16/26	
7	Self Assessment Submissi...		COMPLETE	2/18/26	
8	Team Contract		COMPLETE	2/20/26	
9	Identify Project Goals	Sharmila	COMPLETE	2/20/26	

PROJECT MANAGEMENT TRACKER -
[HTTPS://APP.CLICKUP.COM//V/S/90166307449](https://app.clickup.com//v/s/90166307449)

ClickUp was selected due to its user-friendly interface, minimal complexity, and strong collaborative features.

**Sharmila L**

Role: Team Lead/ Coordinator
Education: A.M.E, BS in Data Science (IITM)
Exp: L.Engineer(Mining/Aviation)

**Arun Barwa**

Role: Data & Analysis Lead
Education: B Tech (Campus-IITM)
Internships: TCS(Pune)

**Prashanth S**

Role: Interview & Stakeholder Lead
Education: BS in Data Science (IITM)
Interests: Reading and Geopolitics

**Priyaghshu Bhattacharyya**

Role: Research Lead
Education: BS in Data Science (IITM)
Interests: Reading Books

**Vidhyasaagar S**

Role: Presentation & Media Lead
Education: BS in Data Science (IITM)
Interests: Chess,crafts,development

Team Profile

We are a diverse team from different parts of India from both Campus and BS students, bringing together internship exposure, professional experience, and young academic minds. One of us interned at TCS (Pune), working on an independent project with interaction across teams and senior researchers. We also have a professional with 10+ years of experience leading teams in the aviation and mining industries.

Short Summary

With backgrounds ranging from Metallurgy, Aviation and Physics to Data-related fields, we combine technical knowledge, industry insight, and fresh thinking to approach problems from multiple perspectives.

Team's Strength

As a team, we are curious, resilient, and driven by high standards. Our collective creativity and analytical mindset enable us to solve problems thoughtfully while respecting diverse perspectives.

Team's Weakness

At times, our pursuit of perfection can lead to overanalysis and delayed decisions. This strong self-expectations can also increase stress and self-criticism.

Team's Opportunity

As a team, we have the opportunity to channel our empathy and rational thinking into becoming strong conflict resolvers and collaborative leaders.

Team's Threat

If not managed well, our perfectionism and high commitment levels may lead to burnout and may also impact confidence and team momentum.

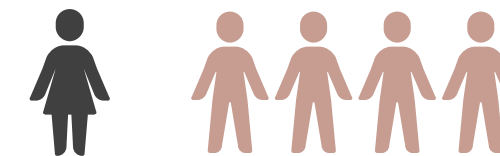
Team Diversity

Experience



1 Experienced | 1 Intern | 3 Fresher

Gender

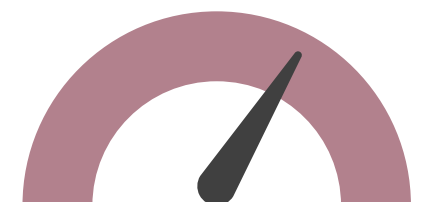


1 Female | 4 Male

Education Background



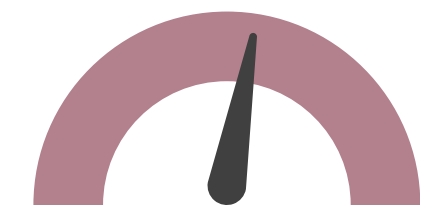
Aviation | Physics | Metallurgy | Data Science



Introvert
2 member

Extrovert
3 member

Working Style



Independent
Thinkers

Team
Collaborators

Discussion Plan

Primary Resource Selection

For primary research, we have identified five individuals from diverse professional and educational backgrounds. These participants were carefully selected to represent varied levels of experience, industries, and exposure to multicultural and remote work environments. Their profiles are outlined below:

- 1. Mr. Sourav Kumar Rout [Computer Science Engineer]** A recent graduate currently working remotely for a Canada-based organization in Business Analytics (Marketing). Collaborates with team members from different cultures and nationalities in a fully remote setup.
- 2. Dr. Balaji [Medical Professional]** – 15 years of experience in the medical field, including service in the Indian Air Force. Has worked in military hospitals in India and civilian hospitals across four countries, with both in-person and remote client interactions. Also has experience working in geographically distinct regions such as Lakshadweep.
- 3. Avinash [Civil Engineer]** – Worked with an international consulting group specializing in engineering and environmental science. Regularly collaborates in cross-functional teams to deliver project outputs.
- 4. Tripti Verma [Localization Manager]** – Over 10 years of corporate experience, currently working at Black Duck as a Localization Manager. Has led localization strategies across businesses, involving extensive interaction with multicultural teams and global stakeholders.
- 5. Kamal Jaiswal [Chemical Engineering Student]** – Third-year undergraduate student involved in advanced projects with postgraduate students and professors. Has collaborated in diverse, tightly knit academic project teams across varied backgrounds.
- 6. Jasmeer Kaur (Aviation Expert)** - Over 5 years of experience in the aviation and manufacturing industries often involves interacting with people from different cultural, linguistic, and professional backgrounds.

These five profiles + 1 profile (Optional) were carefully chosen to provide a balanced mix of early-career professionals, senior industry experts, and emerging young talent. Their combined experiences offer valuable insights into cultural bias, communication dynamics, and inclusion challenges within remote and cross-regional teams.

Interview Plan

Our interview questions include a mix of scenario-based with follow up questions and direct questions designed to gain insights into cultural bias and inclusion in remote teams.

Scenario based Questions

Scenario 1	Imagine you're in a team meeting where a new, high-visibility project is announced. You notice colleagues have already been assigned key roles, but you weren't considered.
Q1	How often have you experienced similar situations?
Q2	Do you believe remote employees are equally considered for high-visibility projects?
Scenario 2	Imagine during a team training, for a doubt raised by a team member, the host switched to local language that you do not understand, and key guidance is shared in that language.
Q3	How inclusive do you find this situation?
Q4	How often have you experienced similar situations?
Q5	What impact would this have on your participation?
Scenario 3	Your virtual background unintentionally reveals aspects of your personal living environment. You later observe differences in how you are included in conversations or opportunities, and you begin to wonder whether visual impressions may be influencing perceptions.
Q6	Have you ever adjusted your camera angle or background to avoid being judged?
Q7	To what extent can visual impressions influence perceptions of professionalism?
Q8	How comfortable do you feel showing your authentic living environment during virtual meetings?
Scenario 4	It's late evening, and you're still finishing a task to meet a deadline. No one knows you logged back in after dinner. The next morning, during the team call, a few colleagues confidently speak about progress and visibility. You completed your part, but you didn't explicitly mention the extra hours or effort. The meeting ends, and you're left wondering whether your commitment and contribution were fully seen
Q9	How often have you experienced something similar?
Q10	To what extent do late hours or behind-the-scenes work go unnoticed?
Q11	In your team, who tends to receive more recognition?
Q12	Have you ever felt indirectly judged because of your geographic location?

Scenario 5

Imagine you are part of a global team working remotely. During informal discussions or project reviews, you hear colleagues refer to the “offshore team” or “that region” in generalized ways, for example, saying they are slower, less proactive, or harder to collaborate with. You realize that the region being discussed is your own. Although the comments are not directed at you personally, you feel indirectly categorized as part of that group.

- Q12 Do generalized statements about regions or “offshore teams” create a sense of division within global teams?
- Q13 In your team, are regional differences discussed with awareness and respect?
- Q14 In such situations, how would you feel?

- Q1 Do you feel you need to provide more evidence or overperform to gain equal recognition?
- Q2 In global remote teams, degrees from Western or globally recognized institutions are given higher credibility. Please share your views
- Q3 Professional credibility in remote teams is sometimes influenced more by institutional brand than by experience. Please share your views
- Q4 Contributions from employees based in certain countries or regions are more readily accepted. Please share your views
- Q5 Have you ever felt your expertise was undervalued due to your geographic location? Please share your views

Custom questions developed to gain detailed insights from the medical professional interviewed.

- A. In a medical field, in-person consultation gives better satisfaction to patients than remote consultation. Does this observation equally true in all the countries that you worked?
- B. In your experience across different countries, does patient satisfaction with remote consultations vary due to cultural expectations or communication styles? If yes, how?
- C. During remote discussions with diagnostic laboratories or medical collaborators, have you ever sensed that your cultural background influenced the depth, clarity, or openness of the communication?
If yes, how did it affect case management or professional confidence?

Topic Selection

Our team was formed based on a shared interest in cross-cultural management. Individually, we explored different topic ideas by referring to various online resources and theoretical frameworks such as **Schein’s organizational culture model** and **Geert Hofstede’s cultural dimensions theory**. After discussing our findings and perspectives as a group, we conducted a collective voting process and selected the topic below that resonated most with the majority of the team.

Beyond Time Zones: How Unconscious Cultural Assumptions Impact Remote Team Success?

Secondary Resource

- American Psychological Association. (n.d.). Addressing bias, stigma, and discrimination in a virtual work environment. [Apaapa.org/pi/health-equity/virtual-work](https://apa.org/pi/health-equity/virtual-work) **Brief info:** Explains how bias, stigma, and discrimination manifest in virtual work environments and provides recommendations for equitable and inclusive remote work practices.
- Donald, B. B., & Brody, M. A. (2023). Toward a more perfect union: Overcoming division, discrimination, and distance through the rule of law. Fordham Law Review, 91, 2099–2126. <https://ir.lawnet.fordham.edu/cgi/viewcontent.cgi?article=1004&context=jirl> **Brief info:** Discusses how remote settings exacerbate unconscious stereotypes and discrimination, recommending legal and organizational strategies to rebuild trust and collaboration.
- Jie, Y. (2023). Employee commitment in virtual teams: State of the art and research directions. Accounting and Corporate Management, 5(11), 47–54. <https://doi.org/10.23977/acccm.2023.051108> **Brief info:** Examines employee commitment in virtual work environments and identifies key factors influencing engagement, performance, and organizational outcomes.
- Powers, H. (2025, March 18). Effects of unconscious bias on the workplace. The Encompass Group. [TheencompassgroupEffects of Unconscious Bias on the Workplace - The Encompass Group](https://theencompassgroup.com/effects-of-unconscious-bias-on-the-workplace/) **Brief info:** Details how unconscious bias in hybrid and remote workplaces leads to unfair evaluations, reduced trust, and decreased productivity.
- Williams, J. C., Lambert, S. J., & Kesavan, S. (2025, March 10). Flexible work, rigid discrimination. SSRN Electronic Journal. https://papers.ssrn.com/sol3/papers.cfm?abstract_id=5173140 **Brief info:** Analyzes unequal access to remote work opportunities due to implicit bias, showing its impact on retention, performance, and diversity.
- Turmel, W. (2013, August 13). Cultural stereotypes can kill remote teams. Management Issues. [Management-issuesCultural stereotypes can kill remote teams](https://www.management-issues.com/cultural-stereotypes-can-kill-remote-teams/) **Brief info:** Explains how cultural stereotypes and communication differences create conflict, misunderstandings, and reduced effectiveness in remote teams.

Thank You

Figure Source:

Team PNG designed by pngtree.com (from “Unity in Multicultural Diversity Team and Friendship Concept”), available at:
https://pngtree.com/freepng/unity-in-multicultural-diversity-team-and-friendship-concept_8816126.html?sol=downref&id=bef

